would unleash a storm of controversy from those who would view it as an attack on religion and the Church. When, in 1857, he began receiving communications from fellow British naturalist Alfred Russel Wallace, who had independently arrived at very similar conclusions, Darwin realized he had to publish his ideas. Papers by Darwin and Wallace were jointly presented at a meeting of the Linnean Society of London in July 1858, under the title “On the Tendency of Species to form Varieties; and on the Perpetuation of Varieties and Species by Natural Means of Selection..

The following year, Darwin published the theory in *On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection*. It offended some scientists because it differed from Lamarck’s ideas of transmutation, and also upset Christian creationists, who argued that it undermined a literal interpretation of the Bible. Others felt that the theory did not account for the huge range of characteristics in species and called it “unguided” and “nonprogressive.”

Darwin was confident. He knew that all individual organisms in a species show a degree of natural variation; some have longer whiskers, or shorter legs, or brighter colors, for instance. Because members of all species compete for limited resources, he deduced that those whose traits are best suited to their environment are more likely to survive and reproduce. He also argued that characteristics that helped an individual organism live longer and reproduce more successfully would be passed on to more offspring, while those that made the organism less successful would be lost. Darwin called this “natural selection”—a process that, over generations, enabled a population of any given species to adapt better and thrive in its chosen habitat.